

KILLER
Marvin Morris

1

You sit to piss in the bathroom stall of a hardcore band at a venue that cost
\$7.00 at the door
Your shoulders marbling forward in your denim vest
you lean forward and read your phone
while smoking a cigarette
Marb Reds, you think as you draw it in
But it would make no difference, in the end
whose flag the 20-strong army of paper-rolled troops waves
You are not picky
Your phone reads:

ARE YOU WHERE YOU NEED TO BE? Y/N

You wait until you're at the sink to type out an *N*
Your cigarette dangles its last two inches over your bottom lip
It falls into the drain
making a sound like *inevitable*
as it rattles against the porcelain
It has been a long time since you dressed like this
the mirror reminds you

This faded shirt
these jeans belong to a dead You
an old
decrepit idea of who You are
to wear them now is not an act of reidentification
to wear them now is to hide
behind a person you once thought you could be

Another man two sinks over wearing black ankle boots with laces
tied tighter around his feet than loitering laws
tighten around the unhomed
His hair issued by his agency
short and cropped
and he
Stares openly at you

"Ahem," he expands his chest
imagining it still has a badge on it
"Are you selling any narcotics?"

You look over
with a coy expression purse your lips
"Ptch-ptch," you kiss at him

He recoils visibly
backing away from you
and leaves the bathroom

You smooch loudly at his retreating behind

He may be going for backup
reporting a hostile kissy-face
rampant homosexual activity in the local dive
But you won't be here long enough for it to matter

When you leave the bathroom you hesitate
Down the hall one end are the mottled lights of the concert
the bobbing silhouette of the crowd
their voices
the bass
and your target
But down the other there is a back entrance
to a smoking place in the alley

You once cornered a dog
saw the way its body crumpled at the back
trying to get away with nowhere to go
fur and muscle bunching up against bricks

You walk down the hall
your work boots noiseless on the tiles

The back entrance is a wooden door
diagonally opposed to the locked green room where outside the band
a punk quartet: The Shitkickers
have left the cases for their instruments

You drag the heaviest to the door
one by one
the turtle shell of the snare drum
the conch for an acoustic hermit crab
thinking about how they built the Pyramids
a thousand workers but one by one

a block at a time

The largest case blocks the bottom of the door frame
and they get smaller as they go
until the back entrance is veritably sealed

You feel your phone vibrate.

MOVE NOW OR AUX WILL TAKE OVER

You scowl at him
It's time to return

Crushing your cigarette on the floor

Your friend from the bathroom stands on the sidelines alone and
far away from your Target
stinging the bartender?

The music tonight is
fine
the singer is screaming herself hoarse
as you watch
one exuberant dancer in the front
careens into a taller audience member

the dancer is pushed back
colliding into the people
breaking up the crowd
which reconstitutes in the form of a group
shoving and pushing and fighting and jumping
a fire at the hearth of the stage
a meteoric process

You almost wish you were here to enjoy it
so you could join in the mosh pit
hiding real jabs and kicks in the frenzied moment
As if he heard your thoughts
your phone says

LOST FOCUS? Y/N

N.
you imagine you're saying it harshly to him.

You push into the crowd.

"Alright we know you guys are fucking sick of us
but please enjoy one last song"

Your Target is on the other side of the stage
near the speakers
bobbing his head with his eyes half-shut

"This is a song that we made just this morning"

You position yourself behind the Target
spotting your Auxiliary
who you motion over

"so it's probably going to sound like shit!! 1-2-3-4!"
the guitarist attacks first
shredding through the air
joined soon by the drummer

The building shakes.

"HOLDING?" you shout in Andrew's ear
your auxiliary support
your so-called partner
whose clothes sag like his backbone

"YEAH, CHANGE YOUR MIND?"

You shake your head and
jerk your thumb at the undercover cop
Andrew
your rival
looks over your shoulder and
raises his eyebrows

"FRIEND OF YOURS?" he furrows his brow

You nod
twisting your expression into one of polite disregard
to deflect his suspicion
releasing it when he's gone
into a pure grin

as Andrew slips through the crowd to sell his wares

No one separates you from your Target now
it is yours to claim
and yours alone

Vocals have joined the instruments
a harmony from all four band members
lead by the powerful lungs of the singer
Her lips change shape
like bubbles in bathwater snapping into each other

You reach forward and tap your Target on the shoulder
He turns to look at you
his eyes instantly filling with dread
his face going slack
Recognition
no different for you than
intimidation

You are already advancing
the crowd blocks the front so
he has nowhere to go but back
and he runs past the speakers into the wings
to the place you just came from

You follow
leisurely

His steps echo in the narrow hallway

As you expected he goes past the bathrooms
thinking he'll slip out to the smoker's alley

Your heels are tapping as you move
with more style than before
the weight of your gun growing heavier in your waistband
You hear him trying to open the green room door
and finding it locked
you hear him go for the back entrance
and desperately
fearfully pulling
throwing the cases down to access it

But he sees you come around the corner
his arms trembling around a guitar case
and he crumbles
dropping the load at his feet
He slumps over the blockade of leather
silver-cornered cases
he's too weak to escape
and now there's nowhere for him to go

"Hey," you say.

He raises his chin towards you
as if you are promising a second chance

You nod
extricating your weapon and taking aim
"I want to see your eyes," you tell him
Brown and wide
fig eyes
his mouth trembles with the words he wants to say:

"Please don't"

You shoot him in the forehead and he pitches
forward

The dog howls
and whines
blood pools around him

it's a halo
a red glorious aura
an omen of hell
a place you long decided was more interesting
than heaven

On your way back
through the windows in the front lobby
you can see Andrew being taken out of the venue
and loaded into an unmarked police car
a black and boxy SUV
You pause by the merchandise table as the two salespeople
nod along to the music with their eyes shut

You take a CD
without them noticing
and go out to your ride

SUCCESS? Y/N

Y

AUXILIARY IN CUSTODY. GET OUT.

You still smell like bathroom and cigarettes
and gunpowder taints your hands
You roll the windows down and drive away in your car
the air sweet like it just rained
the city melting into strips of light

He is waiting for you.

The machine mind man
with nothing in his expression
You cannot read him
you no longer try

You have come to his office in your working clothes
He wrinkles his nose
looking over four desktop monitors and a computer tower
like a king lording over his domain
or a modelist looking proudly at his tiny town
"You
look
and smell
like a gutter."

"Thanks."

"What went wrong?" he asks
"Why did Andrew get caught?"

You shrug
your eyes playing over the bookshelves -
empty -

and the large windows -
covered by curtains

"Shouldn't have been working his side,"
you say,
"on our job. He tried to sell drugs to some
relic
so undercover he couldn't change his shoes."

His black shark's eyes narrow
and he sidles out from behind the desk
his irritating music playing

He is so much smaller in person than he is in your head
You know that your handler's intellectual abilities compensate for
his immaculate
sometimes miniature
appearance

He has many horses on his chariot
many killers on the leash
He directs them like he directed you
or so you assume
with short texts written in capital letters
rarely necessitating a brief answer
as if auto-generated
computerized

You always hated him
but you never mentioned it
Like Andrew it seemed unimportant
a wide black river carries its cargo to the sea
whether you want it to or not

but tonight something snarls and fizzes
your chest smarts
and is that your heart?
or is it something in your blood
that cannot take it anymore?
you look back at him with more indifference than usual:
a superior, godlike oversight
that ironically
you learned from watching him

"This always seems to happen," he observes
"Even the best
wind up meeting their fate
when they're on assignment with you."

"If they're so good
they wouldn't be so easy to fool."
you reason

His face coils up
ready to strike

"So. You admit you're behind it."

You chuckle
darkly
"I've done nothing wrong."

"Zachariah!"
he uses your name like a whip
cracks it across your face
and bares his teeth in a ghoulish smile
no dog -
he is wickedly human.

You interrupt the oncoming lecture
"I don't need backup. Nobody does."

"It works because you work with someone else.
"That's how we avoid making mistakes.
"Like shoddy bandages
there may be holes
but the cloth under
or the cloth over
holds the blood in."
he rests his hip against the desk
"I have to deal with this
situation,"
he looks away for a moment
lost in thought

Then looks at you with an infuriating
childlike smugness
"We're through."

You stare at him
and

As your urge to kill intensifies
his TOOL song plays from two speakers
vibrating
thudding bookends of the desk
filling the room with
music that strikes you as an
introverted rock and roll

He tried to explain TOOL to you once
why what they did was somehow different
more masterful
than the music of others -
you can remember only one word from this lecture:

polyrhythms

"You're thinking of killing me, aren't you?"

He has thin brown hair parted down the middle
falling around his face
a ripped screen door
a spiderweb across the cheek while walking between two trees

His face is uncannily young
and his eyes are like unlit coals
He is the color of the devil
white as ash on the edge of an old fire

His deep eyes are widening around the edges

You
are
indeed thinking of it
and the fact that he knows that
heightens the urge
Like a mirrored flick of the eyes to lips
on the first date.

He is watching you go for your gun
His body is blurring

He is shouting "You--!"

and
diving towards your midsection
pinning your firing wrist with both his hands
as if stopping a leak in the floor of his ship

your finger twitches away from the trigger
holding off
while your free fist goes into the side of his face
and he careens into the desk next to you both

You feel the gun leave your fingers
you've tossed it to the side
straddled his belly
slipped his wrists under your knees

He screams

You cover his mouth with your hand
His eyes turning red
As you hold him
he begins to cry
wail
bite your palm without purchase

now
an animal
a beast worthy of death

You strangle him on the floor of his office
until his eyes slide closed

until he isn't fighting anymore
until his heart stops
until the nine-minute song has come to a close

your hands finally loosen

Then you kiss him
on the nose
and destroy his computers

As you slide back into the seat of your car you become aware that something is wrong
like a spider under your clothes

Everyone knows you drive a 67 Mustang
Her keys have graced the center of the card table as the ring on the finger of your bluff
Her angular hood precedes your death-step like the snout of a black horse
snorting hot air and pawing at the ground
aware of her master's mission
the way a cowboy's horse knows the songs he sings

She'll get you caught.

You park it thirty miles away from your own master's
body
in a quiet parking lot
on the topmost level

You climb out and lock it
hiding the keys in the wheel well

Your phone stays silent
like a tombstone weighing in your pocket
They'll come for you soon
or they'll try to

His organization isn't one you leave
He isn't a person you kill
yet the world feels
no less
no more
empty without him.

The last person who tried on his life
wound up under your sights just the same
They had sparkling brown eyes
sentient marbles rolling down a silver chute towards the end

You wonder who they'll send
and when

There's no going back to your apartment complex

They'll be waiting for you there
No scaling the dirty stairs to the fourth floor
No wafting mildew in your kitchen
Always a temporary domicile
for you -
cheap and temporary.

And it's almost a relief to be on the streets
to have nowhere to be and nowhere to go
The world seems open to you
lying flat on her back with her arms and legs
spread

You're armed and semi-wealthy

still
you don't know how long you can live out here
This is no mountain wilderness demanding clearly from you
water, shelter, food
activating the dormant hunter's urge that all men must have

The fertile ground has been covered in concrete
every potential home built
and all the buildings like fortresses that hold you at bay
Sustenance cannot be found, only bought
and purpose dashes itself like light snow on concrete

As the night gets longer you see the people who are out with you

Walking with cigarettes and backpacks
suitcases
luggage carts
hiking boots and sturdy pants
dogs and huge pockets and cardboard signs
lit cigarettes
dirty nails
under the streetlights

Some faces drawn
others painted with optimism
others unreadable as your boss
their eyes so dim
it makes you taste blood

As you approach an underpass you hear loud voices
neither angry nor excited
just loud

Outside voices

They remind you of the idea of summer camp
Of words like
field day
county fair
and festival

It's a gathering of people
Smoke hangs in a cloud above them all
pot and meat and tobacco shaking hands hazily from mouths with air
And the smell of cooking in the smoggy city atmosphere
At the center of the group there's a portable grill
a girl with bleach blonde
star-shaped hair and heavily tattooed brown skin
turns franks with a smile

"You homeless?" someone asks you.

"Yeah," you say
shaking their hand

"Want a hot dog?"

bikes and animals and litter and reggaeton fill the gaps between the people
the fire whipping the shadow of its tongues on the wall
you let them feed you and in return
you take the most stalwart five
Max, two Johns, a Robert, a Franklin
to the nearby liquor store
you buy three cartons of cigarettes
four handles of vodka so cheap it could be water
and a case of bourbon
the money that your handler placed in your bank account
seventy five grand the last time you checked
seems like mist

they celebrate

they shout and run

like it's Halloween tonight
handing things out gleefully and crediting
who else?
You
sit beneath the overpass and watch them drink
suckling on your own tender glass duct of bourbon

normal people walking on the bridge are talking
walking
"and he said I was the reincarnation of a famous singer,"
"which one?"

"the death cycle isn't finite," a woman calls out
only just decipherable
while crouched behind a tree and urinating

The people on the bridge hurry along
"Elvis," one of them says distantly, "or
Michael Jackson."

you watch the woman's flanks as they disappear into her skirt again
her business concluded she turns towards you and the ruckus under the bridge
already ready with a cigarette
that you light for her

"my name's Corny," she tells you
about sixty five
her hair braided minutely

"Corny" you repeat dubiously

"Cornelia"

"Okay."

as you are thanked
passed a joint
which you inhale
knowing that you cannot be affected by drugs
Corny watches you
watches the crowd

she has unbeautiful eyes

so piled and wrinkled they give only the impression of a turtle poking its head out to seize a cherry tomato between its little teeth

"how long have you been out here?"

"Not long," you watch her pull smoke between the graypink lines of her lips
someone hollers in the crowd
she wraps her hand around your elbow
her skin is warm
You turn and don't know why but you
look for signs of death in Corny
expecting her to be cold
with no heartbeat
expecting her silence
not even the suggestion of brain activity

"Will you come with me?" you ask
and take her to the shadows
far from the bridge
covered in darkness
She holds out another cigarette but
You

You wrestle her to the ground
cover her mouth
just like him
just like so many others
You're reminded of torturing dolls as a child
You pull out her hair fist by fist
woven bunches of silver-black flax growing lush from her purple
pink
brown body
You hit her until she bleeds wet on your knuckles
you lick it off
and she stares at you with her ugly gaze
you shudder
but you take it nonetheless
beating her from
Corny
to
Cornelia
to
nothing.

The party rages on through the nighttime
though even those without four walls and a full bed have to sleep
somewhere
The grillmaster climbs on a bike
and sets off among
and with other groups who seem to know one another distantly
not as friends but as old relatives
those people that cannot be denied
people bound together loosely
comfortably
who fall step-in-step and return to their camps
as buddies
a few hours before daylight

You have nowhere to sleep.

You remain under the bridge with a few who you took to the store
your bloody hands shoved in your pockets
Robert passed out face-down
two of them leaning shoulders against the cement walls
"last i heard she was
going to the shelter."
"maybe that's where she is."
"but there's the curfew," John urges
"she would've missed it by the time she left."
Max is standing
staring
at you.

"so maybe she went back. when we can stand
we'll go look for her."

You sink down against the wall
and Max glances at you

"good night, Zachariah," he says
quietly

You look at his face
his features delicate and unnaturally aged
tobacco smoke has broken down his cheeks and forehead
put wrinkles and acne over his tan and sandy expression

for a moment
You feel compelled to tell him as exhaustion crawls up your back

I'm not what you think I am and you shouldn't have trusted me

I find nothing but acceptance in the world
and you were a fool to think

that I would ever be un-glorious.

And as you close your eyes
the air warm and summery tonight
you see them

All the people staring back at you
fig eyes
coal eyes
turtle eyes
Eyes before tonight too
agate
scotch-amber
cocoa
sage
ice-blue
Your souvenirs
tearful muddy green
gilded hazelnut
pale pink albino
You treasure them all
like cages full of birds
like a case in a museum with your name placarded across the base
like profitable stocks and assets in a fat file folder

Yes
You know you want blood.
All of these eyes shining
winking
sparkling
like the innumerable stars that the bridge obscures from sight
these people are yours
became so once you saw their insides
once you took
from them

Somehow it is no longer killing -
 not a clinical, culinary, butchery
 of removing a life for a reason -
 now it is becoming a cause of death
 becoming death itself

God
 a force that takes from all things that pass beneath its omnipotent hand

The summer air has a chill in it
 as consciousness slips away from you
 Imagine dumping ice into a warm bath
 As the shuffle of feet fail to disturb you
 and the shifting of some
 unnamed season
 some moon phase
 some exchange of the planets
 takes place in the sky far away.

2

The morning arrives to you
 alone
 palely full of fog
 wrappers on the ground next to you
 an electric charge in the air
 a crackling static
 a wind that smells nothing like your city

Rot
 fat mushrooms
 permeate the air
 like the mildew in your old place

Or a forest floor
 or a grave
 there is a sound too hidden in the brush of wind
 a shuffling and dragging
 heavy weight in a damp bag leaving a track on the ground
 there are no cars driving on the bridge
 no footsteps and no conversation
 the day is as quiet as New Year's Morning.

You feel light

pat your pockets
and sinking realize

Your wallet is gone
so is your gun
your phone
and your watch

You are struck by your nakedness
cursing
your generosity with the unhoused
You stand up and hit the wall of the underpass with your bare fist
hands still covered in Corny's blood
now covered with your blood too
your knuckles split

pain coursing through your body
a fire alarm in an abandoned building
sounding warning for nobody
You scream in anger
the sound is good in you
you scream again
howling like a dog locked outside

You silence yourself.
You are no dog.
You
can survive.

The only place for you to go is to your Mustang
where you have weapons, ID
your backup phone
Even if they are looking for you there
you cannot possibly live like this
whoever robbed you
taking away even the bare decency of knowing what time it is

You get to your feet still wearing your shoes and your dirty-You punk clothes
and stalk down the sidewalk back towards the parking center

It must be early
because no one is out
though the fog makes it difficult to tell
every fifteen feet is obscured thickly by the clouds

the sky a sheet of blank gray-white tissue paper stretched above you
no sun
no stars
no moon
It is eerie how alone you feel there on the city sidewalk
somewhat aggravating
It is the silence
you tell yourself
and you won't dwell on the creeping sensation
that accompanies solitude

Your rationale is quickly rewarded
by a silhouette

another person
who you see
moving slowly towards you from the edge of the fog

but

why does she walk that way?

legs shuddering forward
one at a time
her arms swinging lifelessly at her sides
her head sagging above her chest
at first
she seems faceless

then she grows close enough for you to see her head
full of patches
where someone has ripped her hair out in places
a tortured doll given height
dragging herself into view

her face is mutilated
a lopsided mouth

You can see where there was once the
pull of a cigarette in the twisted graypink lines of her destroyed jaw
and your heart
stops

She has no eyes

Where they should be
the center of pitted olives
a vacuumed crawlspace
receding tide pools casting black flotsam
on volcanic rock

no eyes to show the pain
you tell yourself she must be in

She is ambling towards you and

there are others around
dark bodies in the parting fog

not just the walking ones tilting towards you
the way she is
but ravaged limp bodies on the ground
surrounded by blood and viscera

People
sloping out of their cars
missing pieces
or strewn mid-run towards the underpass
legs separated from
hips

ignored by the shuffling
meandering
crowd
that has noticed you even in the fog

There was never fear like this
not when you first killed
your mother
not in the face of religious authorities
scolding you at your tenderest age

never not ever

it feels like fingers
holding onto your spine and your shoulders
long cold fingers wrapping around you
freezing you in place

setting you up
a pin in the alley

no

no no
you run
it spreads into your arms and legs
hot and cold
Your heart already beating so hard you can feel it in your ears
as you break into a sprint
running past
Corny's body where it stands

you hear her foot pivot
slowly and grating
like sandpaper on wood
and you know she is coming after you

ssshhh
it sounds like
and together all of those bodies
shush you as you run
asking you for silence with the low
gruff drag
of their legs

the trip from here to your destination seemed much shorter at night
the buildings covered in fog
the streets abandoned but for
deadened
heavy bodies
that look towards you as you dodge them
or that do not move at all

wolves
the standing ones turn with the scent
cold lifeless bodies aligning painlessly in their purpose
to take you to the ground
passively
indifferently
slow as lichen

Their feet slide across the ground

eyeless faces turning
before the rest of their bodies

You run weakly
placing speed first and endurance second
lungs last
so by the time you pause at the entryway of the towering parking lot
you are breathless
gasping
and you can practically hear the drill instructor shouting
over the sound of many legs carrying many lifeless silhouettes
to move your sorry ass

The stairs are numerous
Panic courses through you
the worst poison
seizing your nerves and making your breath come out in pathetic sobs
as you scramble up the stairs
the fear something other than fear

because man's feelings must be productive
and this only slows you down

Your car is waiting for you.

No one has stolen it
touched it
You grope beneath the wheel well
praying softly
ignoring the reflection of your twisted expression

You sigh with audible relief
close your fingers around the jagged pieces
of keys
when a hand takes a hold of your shoulder and a body
groans
keeling
on top of you
her mouth open
You feel her teeth scrape your skull and you react
sending your fist into her nose
your elbow into her ribs
her gray blue body explodes across the ground
leaving only the impression of vacuous eyeholes on the tops of your fingers

the sensation of dry kindling on the outside of your elbow

You would have seen her approach had you
looked at your reflection

Now you hear them
on the stairs
coming from below

Your Mustang is good to you
She winnies when you put the recovered keys in the ignition
takes off with a broken mare's steadfast pleasure
as your hand fondles the stick and your feet work her pedals

The radio
only plays static

With shaking fingers
You put on the CD that you took from the band table
what feels like thousands of years ago
and
as you revel in the safety of your vehicle
a game reveals itself to you

Down the parking garage ramps the bodies litter your path
but the front of your car mows over them like a righteous mouth
swallowing
with a bounce of digestion under your tires

the excretion of the toppled body in the rear window

You make it to the streets and even in the fog
you are able to navigate
so that you hit as many of them as possible
your car swerving left and right
over curbs
around corners you swing the vehicle to hit three at once
turning them to nothing on the asphalt
you find yourself laughing and
turning up the music
wondering why you were so terrified of these
bags
on legs
That are nothing to your horsepower

You drive manically through the city on a warpath
 looking for anywhere uninhabited
 but every place seems to be filled with them
 inexplicably
 as if you slept for days before this happened
 and missed the last hours of the living

You find one spot but when you open the door you hear the quiet
 shushing of dragged toes

You smell the rotten
 mushroom
 air
 and you must run again
 the gas dwindling on your dashboard.

Finally you park your car on the highway
 the one that leads out to the outlet stores
 the fireworks stand in July
 the liquor stores on Sundays
 You dig through the belongings that you so wisely placed inside this car
 the burner phone
 it is dead, still, and crunches in your frustrated hand
 its exoskeleton brittle like a beetle carcass on a windowsill
 you have no new batteries
 your fake passport and ID
 for whatever good they would have been
 have been soaking in spilled lighter fluid in your glove compartment for months
 and worse
 there is no weapon.

Not even your hunting knife
 and you do get out and check the back
 finding that the only things you put there were
 a change of clothes:
 athletic shorts and running shoes
 a hoodie
 a big lighter
 a crumpled stale
 plastic bag of tobacco

How could You be so unprepared?
 You

a killer?
a glorious killer?
free -
living outside of society
a lone wolf
independent

You remember
having your handler requisition food
weapons and supplies
providing a safe place to live
giving you the support you
didn't think was necessary.
You were satisfied for some time with
always knowing where you needed to be and what to do
and why did that fail?
If it hadn't
then now
you wouldn't be on your own.

You start to change your clothes
shucking away your work boots
and your jeans
fly out of your grip in a strong gust
leaving you empty-handed and
bare-assed just as a 16-wheeler passes you by
laying tauntingly on the horn

You watch it going away from the city
with the lost expression of someone having missed a boat

Could you follow?

flag it down?
ask questions?

see if it goes somewhere different from here?

but you know
like you know you're hungry
that the truck driver is no more aware of the big picture than you
perhaps even less so because at least
you know it is the dead that have risen
to kill the living.

And what about your handler?
 has he risen too?
 in this new state
 can you still get something from him?

But the thought is squashed as you remember
 the old notion of unfinished business

it would be worst
 to re-encounter him.

For once you cannot leave the city and you cannot return to it
 the same thing lies in either direction
 only uncertainty
 and danger

In
 desperation
 you elect to drive to the only place that may be your salvation
 A place not only stocked with weapons and fortified against attack
 a place where people are prepared for crisis
 a place where they might help you.

The police station
 looms
 as you park your car outside
 you recall how often you worked against these very men
 men that in another world you might have been able to respect
 men of action
 that is:
 men of power.

You book it up the stairs
 past the scattered crowd of lurking bodies
 and make it to the doors only to find them
 locked
 securely bolted
 furniture piled up against them from the inside

"HEY
 "LET ME IN

"I'M NOT ONE OF THEM,"
you scream through the bulletproof glass
pounding your blood-soaked fists on the narrow windows
"I SURVIVED,"
as soft mumbling on the ground rises in volume behind you
ssshh.

As nothing happens
Your hands are getting desperate
the fractured one from this morning's outburst sending shoots
bamboo-like pain-stems
streaming into your muscles
as if they searched for sunlight
as you search for sanctuary
with every impact
"PLEASE
"PLEASE, GOD."

A shot rings out from a far window of the station
and as it pierces through your right arm
spreading pain and fatigue through your bicep
you see the silhouette of a man in uniform holding a rifle towards you
through the frame of the window
one leg balancing him inside
the other elbowed on the sill

You scream in rage
only one fist now able to crash
time and time again against the door
You sink to your knees involuntarily
but he fires again
this time hitting a body behind you
that slumps onto the ground.

The police officer begins to shoot rapidly
spraying bullets into the shadowy mass behind you -
the whole hoard of them silent
but for the deafening soft shuffle
the ubiquitous heavy thud

You now remain on the ground
in gratitude
on your knees looking up at the fluorescent lights inside
flickering between the boarded-up door like gold in the darkness of a cavern

Taking a moment to rest on the stoop on Father's lap

The enormous Father who
 with a hand lifts you up
 Though his cold caring fingertips bruise
 sometimes
 it's never to hurt:
 the burden of Fatherhood makes people coarse but loving
 and they are ever-acting in your interest

You wish often to be a Father
 and it is that element too that bolsters
 but makes fetid Fatherhood:
 the envy of the power to hurt righteously.

as your head spins with these thoughts
 you become aware that the shushing of feet has temporarily stopped
 mowed down
 and the officer
 one hand cupped around his mouth
 one hand holding his weapon
 is calling out to you:

"THIS AREA IS FOR AUTHORIZED PERSONNEL ONLY.
 "YOUR PRESENCE IS CONSIDERED ENDANGERMENT.
 "IF YOU DO NOT RETREAT, I WILL SHOOT
 "REPEAT, I WILL SHOOT."

You hold your arm gritting your teeth
 "PLEASE,"
 you drag yourself up on the door with your good
 left arm
 "I NEED HELP."

he aims the weapon
 but you refuse to cry out again
 or to beg

Father challenges you now to survive
 and you must.

You return to your car
 sink into the passenger seat and struggle to push the keys in with your right arm
 between your cracked hand and shot shoulder

it is also impossible to turn the key with and worse
you drive a stick shift.

Suppressing a cry of pain
you push the clutch into place
You turn the keys with your left hand
and as you twist to take the car out of neutral
leaning your shoulder against the wheel to direct it as it begins to roll
you slip a little and press against the horn

but you're already leaning on the accelerator and
you get your hand on the wheel as the Mustang jumps forward
engine grinding as you speed up
turning away from the police station as the officer fires a warning round
into your rearview mirror

as you twist to change gears again
the car complaining loudly
a twinge of pain jerks your legs up
and your signature vehicle stalls

You feel tears prick your eyes
frustration
betrayal
another shot rings out and hits the back of the car
"OK" you scream
and do the whole thing over again

Body shaking as you press down the clutch
put the stick back in neutral
your left hand trembling to turn the keys
then as your bloody right arm snags against the chair behind you

You grab the stick and shift it into first
and your feet carefully
balance between pressing down the accelerator
letting off the clutch
and with another sickening lurch you're off

This time you sit yourself up
and keep the car below
fifteen miles per hour

this time you don't hit anyone

except on accident

and even then they seem to slide beneath the tires
and come out the other side only bruised
rising off the ground

it is difficult enough to drive
that you take no pleasure in it
and for some time, you don't know where you're going.

But injuries and wounds
are not unusual to your life
You have spent many hours in
hospitals
and on a day like this where else would the living people gather
than the place meant to heal
soothe?
the place of nurture

You received medical care from the organization before
the one of the man you worked for
the machine mind who
becomes more and more nameless
the longer this day becomes
as you crawl on four wheels through the daylight streets
clouds still darken the sky and piles of bloody corpses darken the road

In an office building
that was being renovated
Your boss had paid someone to stitch your head shut
after you fell three stories
escaping the police
But you received medical care often as a child too
for wounds you earned through
battle and discipline

And in hospitals you take particular comfort
having been a child who the nurses always
liked
for your charm and your tough kid act
plus
they were already happy due to your parents'
comprehensive health insurance

You always admired hospital workers
 who distinguish themselves somewhat like law enforcement
 by taking power over those in pain
 overseeing a decay that most are afraid of
 that is moral decay
 as well as physical rot

So the hospital appears to you a
 lovely white citadel

though you see the doors are boarded too
 You
 will not be kept out

You
 summon up your strength and slam the accelerator
 turning the car away from the parking area
 You head across the green lawn of the building
 where the patients might have one day
 walked leisurely
 and
 you hit the entryway of the hospital with your car

Sending lobby chairs and tables flying in all directions
 rubble from the walls explodes outwards
 dust rising
 You snag nonetheless
 as the walls of the hospital wrap around the car doors
 your feet are taken from the pedals
 you are thrown through the windshield

and rendered immediately unconscious.

3

While you lie on the floor
 against the rubber baseboard in the green and gray waiting room
 the hospital is quiet

No one comes to get you
 nothing touches you in your slumber
 no teeth
 but
 you see visions of movement around your body

as if you float above it
 Your mind no more than mist
 and you think you can see them clearly
 but dazedly
 as if in a dream.

They are humanlike
 their walks are similar but there are
 idiosyncracies
 in each shift of weight and
 in the wounds they carry
 the sickly shades of skin the
 shape of the holes that should have their eyes
 as if there is an identity buried in the skin they drag around
 the muscle memories
 of a person who moved their chin habitually up with imperiousness
 someone whose fingers twitched lightly
 someone who moved briskly and with purpose
 who doesn't look up or
 who slumps
 That which the bodies are so accustomed to
 they do them even while there is no mind behind them
 As if their shadows
 are as much people as them

And though it seems that for a second
 your body might rise up too while your mind
 floats in this semi-living space

You do not die here.

You open your eyes slowly
 The pain is so thorough it is almost like you feel nothing
 and you see that the hallways that extend
 deeper into the hospital
 are empty.

You get to your feet and walk to the right.

Your ears keep playing tricks on you
 producing a quiet shh
 clicks
 bumps
 around every corner

every open room
but nothing appears

You try the second floor
an inpatient ward
and are certain that you do hear
a ssh
coming from one of the rooms though

it is pneumatic
hydraulic
it does not sound like heavy feet on floors
nor does it come nearer
it is even muffled.

You creep slowly to a closed door
near the end of the hallway
nose wrinkling at that familiar clinical aroma

And twist open the knob
violently
ready to take attack

but inside
the force of the open door has sent a chair
a former blockade
skittering across the tiles
the curtains are drawn and a few machines are running
a nurse lies dead and chewed up on the floor

You conduct a thorough search
throwing her body to the side
rummaging through the cabinets
looking under the stretchers
and when you throw open the closed bathroom door
you see inside
a red-spotted girl sits in her hospital bed
wide awake with a tired expression
looking at you with large
eyes

The bathroom is loaded with medical supplies
and medical machines
and

This child
connected to
a respirator

"Who are you?"
she asks.

You slide the door behind you
shutting it
and say
"What happened?"

"

Sam put me in here
when one of them
came
"

She is hesitant
stares at you
with her
bright golden eyes

For a split second
you wish for hesitation

for anything to stop you from doing now
what you know is imperative to do

for a greater God to take your hands and pin them to your sides.

But you
have no reason to wish
No one is here to punish you for your actions
No one is here but You

so
with a single strike
to the center of her chest
You kill her

After

You're
bandaging and cleaning yourself in the hospital room bathroom
desperately wishing for a smoke
and you find it funny that the nurse
hasn't come back to life
hungry
let alone anybody you saw on the streets -
Surely
you would have noticed if they stood up
but the eaten people stayed down and none of the walking bodies
had pieces taken out of them
except for the ones you took
out of Corny

You consider that the effects of this cosmological event
may be temporary
And it could be that
once all of the carnivorous bodies are shot down
everyone can go on living

You have many broken bones but
you can stand
and you pluck the glass out of your skin

clean the wounds with antiseptic and wrap them up
For now you leave the bullet
guessing there will be a surgery room with better equipment
later on
Guessing
everything will work out okay.

There is something about this new world
this world where you can kill anyone
on impulse
where the cops are holed up where
death barely means anything anymore;
Yes
there are things you enjoy here

Maybe
this wouldn't have to end
and you could still be happy
finally independent even:
finally able to act without true fear of consequence

so long as you keep your wits about you:

This is not a choice of one letter
sent to a man far away

N/

Y

This is your choice
and you know which one you want to make

You take the handle of the bathroom door in your palm and turn it
entering the child's room as

she

dives at you

small

ravenous

and wraps around your legs

biting into your calf hungrily and looking up at you

with big

empty eyes

reanimated

not lively

You grab her by the hair and try
to pull her off

Her ponytail comes out
in your hand with bits of
scalp

You retch

and throw it aside and she

rips a piece of your calf muscle out in her teeth

pain lancing up from where your leg

once worked

it forces you to drop to the floor

You kick out

and by some luck

you push her off

Foot in her chest she tumbles

Back

and away

Once more it is not time for you to die

Again you are too fast

and you limp towards the door
sobbing
finding your way with bleary eyes to the stairwell but
your injured leg stings as you try to bring it forward and
you fall
down

the flights of concrete stairs connecting with neck
back
elbows
legs
until you reach the bottom
there's no place that isn't hit
including where your head was stitched closed
all those months ago
splitting it open again
adding to the impossible pain
the endless agony you find yourself in

You cannot comprehend why death hasn't taken you yet.

it almost seems unfair:
as you lie on your back at the bottom of the stairwell
you are dismayed to find you
still have the strength to reach a door
beneath a small M on the wall
that must stand for
Medical Department
you knock away the door-stopper someone jammed beneath it

drag your body limply
upwards
your feet shushing against the ground as you try not to slip
on your own blood

You push inside
and

there is a little sound
almost like metal cracking
there

as you walk into the main room
are drawers
rattling

Steel drawers
facing an examination table
They are shuddering
as the things inside of them
fight

The fear is on you again
you
in the Morgue

Some of them have created gaps between the drawers
and the walls
The well-greased tracks they lie on top of
allowing gravity to make those gaps
thicker
You back up
and hit a patch
of
cold bare skin
that
wraps around you
bends down and takes
a bite
from your tenderized body

the drawers opening now
and so many faces coming out of them
overwhelmingly unidentical
yet all
turned towards you

and as you crane your neck to try and escape
the body behind you
you see that it is the naked
fresh-faced
empty-eyed
body
of your handler

who must have been on the slab when this happened

who
seems to have waited for you

you can barely pull away from his cloying
cold embrace
and drawers steady flow does not let up
sliding out
letting free the undressed bodies
gray and pink and swinging their parts

and like the dog
like a soon-to-be body
no exit in sight
howling
and bleeding

You find that the onslaught of pain blinds you to time
as they all tear into you
 how it could be centuries
 how it might as well be
 as teeth connect with tissue and empty eyes
 passively watch you go down underneath them
 your screams becoming silent as you lose your mind
 your vocal chords
 your skin
 your desire to live

and it is unclear when you die
but eventually
great relief approaches
orgasmic:
a dizzying
paralytic
relief

It takes you from yourself

Before then all sensation had become
unbearable
dull blades and visceral removal
so disgusting
perpetrated by such lifeless creatures
you in fact prayed for it to end

but you were not sentient enough to repent
as you had always secretly planned to do
and
You see
yourself.

You see Him
not God
but Zachariah:

He is
being consumed completely
By creatures who
from this new position it becomes evident
have no souls.

He is being taken from his bones
and destroyed
erased completely
like a whale at the bottom of the ocean being picked clean
and as the meaningless time dwindles meat down to marrow
the bodies around him eventually
move on

They go through the door he left open
They find the few people who remain in the hospital

A few eat the eyes first

The rest of the dead move through the world steadily
and take it from the living
maybe forever hungry
maybe satiated
once everyone is gone
it is unknown -

You
on the other hand
you return to something you had forgotten

a place of immense knowledge
that you cannot articulate
where you are warm and yet without feeling
where it seems

everyone is.

You disappear from the face of the Earth and reappear
not Him
not You
but simply

in
a vast ocean

you can see it all from here
swimming on the top of the Sun
and everything is illuminated

You can see
past your own life
past his
past the planets
past the universe to where

there are hundreds
thousands
billions
of eyes

his collected eyes
are there
and all others
even the ones of the bodies
that killed You
every set accounted for but the ones
still blinking
crying
turning red
in the world of the living

these eyes are watching
not the Earth as you know it and the catastrophe playing out there
instead they are all looking at
You
as you melt back into that thing you forgot

opening your eyes
to look at Him.

THE END